strength, the octogenarian fought off the Afghan with his whip, but only just escaped. Wounded on his neck, head and face, Munim Khan was carried away from the battlefield, barely conscious. The Mughals had lost two generals, one after the other; how long would it be before they lost heart? Todar Mal yelled at a man who came with news of Khan Alam and Munim, 'Don't prate, and don't say such things'.

The battle 'hung in the balance between the Rajah and Daud' – until the news came. Another 'arrow from the quiver of fate' had found its mark. It had struck Gujar Khan and killed him. Daud heard the news and fled. A miraculous victory for Akbar's army, once again.

Could it be that such consistent luck went to Akbar's head; or is it possible that his soldiers, his courtiers, his subjects began to believe there was something truly exceptional about their emperor, that he was blessed? Perhaps a bit of both, and its result was clear: 'Akbar, of all the Mughal Emperors,' writes the modern historian Harbans Mukhia, '. . . became the embodiment of many miraculous powers.'[27]

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A few months after the Battle of Tukaroi, another contingent of Mughals and Afghans were battling in the east. A Mughal soldier fell unconscious in the battlefield and would, no doubt, have died, except that a vision of Akbar came to him, riding a 'steed of fortune . . . equipped for battle, and bringing the good news of victory'. The apparition lifted the soldier 'from the dust' and sent him back into the fray.[28]

Another Mughal soldier, Peshrau Khan, imprisoned and sentenced to die by a powerful Bihari zamindar, was taken by a 'scoundrel' to meet his end. At the moment of his execution, however, Peshrau Khan began to meditate on Akbar – and lo! 'however much I tried, my arm refused to act [against you]', the executioner exclaimed. A second executioner, too, was unable to harm the supernaturally protected Mughal, who managed to escape and return to court, where he told his tale.

Not everyone embraced the idea of Akbar's miraculous powers with equal enthusiasm. No man can be a hero to his harem, after all. In May 1577, half a year or so after the Peshrau Khan affair, Abul Fazl describes Akbar the 'loving lord bent in meditation' by his elder son's bed, prophesying the end